

KF Mini-Meeting Lesson 21

--"MINI-MEETING" FORMAT-- (20 min)

I - MINDFULNESS (4 min)

-ANB (1 min)

-3 Minute Breathing Space (3 min)

II - CHECK-IN (10 min)

-KF Member "A" shares (5 min)

(1) What I learned

(2) Signs of MO

(3) Signs of Orientation

(4) Five things I am thankful for

-KF Member "B" shares (5 min)

(1) What I learned

(2) Signs of MO

(3) Signs of Orientation

(4) Five things I am thankful for

III - KF MEETING "PREVIEW" (6 min)

-Bible Teaching -- selected excerpt of previous week KF Bible teaching (5 min)

-Ending Prayer (1 min)

BIBLE TEACHING

We are our own worst enemy. Let's stop blaming others or our circumstances and acknowledge that our real enemy is ourselves.

Last week we began looking at **Psalm 23** from a KF perspective. Here is a summary of what we learned:

1. The Lord our Shepherd meets our real needs

Jesus said, "I am the good Shepherd." He provides the security and support that we need in order to give up our Idol's law and pride system.

2. It is Jesus who restores, or repairs, our soul

Our redeemed and alive soul is our True Self. Jesus created our soul and He knows how to repair it. He wants to help us become who He created us to be.

3. The Idol Self will not support the restoration of our soul

To maintain its survival and power, the Idol Self will resist any effort you make to restore your True Self. If you choose humility and freedom, the Idol will fiercely oppose your efforts using fear and self-hate as its weapons. You will enter the valley of the shadow of death.

4. The Shepherd's rod and staff guide and help us

Under the Shepherd's care, we can refuse to be guided by our shoulds, taboos, and claims and learn to respond to His rod and staff. The Shepherd skillfully trains and guides each of His sheep according to their needs and choices. He knows what training and provision each one needs to help them maintain an oriented path.

Now let's look at **Psalm 23:5-6**. Nancy has translated the rest of this psalm using some alternative vocabulary to help expand our understanding.

⁵You set in order before me a table with my particular limitations.

You have enriched my head with oil;
My cup overflows with abundance.

⁶Good things and kindnesses will follow after me all the days of my life,
And throughout my life I will return to the house of the Lord.

Take a deep breath.

Most of us have heard that the Lord prepares a table before us *in the presence of enemies*. According to Strong's Concordance, the Hebrew word for enemies also means a narrow place, or a binding, as in being tied up. There is a sense of distress and limitation as in a city besieged. In order to give us a more thorough understanding of this psalm, Nancy has conveyed this idea of restriction by using the word *limitations*. When we meet with limitations, we often feel distressed, or under siege, because we perceive these limitations as obstacles to our happiness and satisfaction. Let's listen to verse 5 again in Nancy's translation: *You set in order before me a table with my particular limitations. (Repeat)* Your table is set with limitations that are uniquely yours. They are part of the abundance that is promised to you through the picture of anointing oil and a cup that overflows. How can that be?

Real limitations protect us. The Shepherd knows what we can handle at our present stage of development, and He uses real limitations to help protect us from what we cannot handle. When we mindfully accept what *is*, and courageously sit at the table ordered for *us*, our limitations become part of our strategy rather than the focus of our judgments. We discover our potential by learning to be creative and by working within the realities of our limitations.⁴

In misorientation, however, we can rarely imagine this potential. We are focused on what *should* be, so rather than exploring our real potential in a particular situation, we feel discontent and disappointed. We look around at other people's tables and feel the unfairness of not having this or that benefit. This is neurotic envy.

The promise that goodness and kindnesses will follow us and that our home is with the Lord our Shepherd inspires us to courageously sit at our own table and stop looking around at other tables. At this point, we must ask ourselves: *Do I want to leave a trail of goodness, health, and compassionate mercy behind me, or would I rather continue to work hard at actualizing my Idol Self in this world? Do I want to make the most of the reality of my condition in this material world, with my particular challenges and strengths, or am I only interested in my judgment of how things should be? What do I want?*

What do you want?

Our prayer might go something like this:

Shepherd, I want to leave behind me a trail of goodness and kindnesses. Help me make that happen. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for this time of healing and training. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You continue to guide us to our real glory and to the truth of who you created us to be. With Your rod and staff, train us for the next step as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self and design, with the Creation and the community, and with You, for the honor and glory of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.